

GIANT FISH

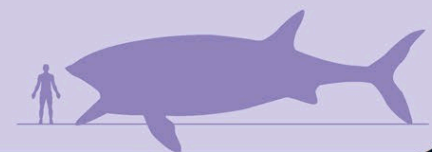
LEEDSICHTHYS

The Jurassic waters were home to the massive *Leedsichthys*, the largest bony fish ever to swim in the ocean. This prehistoric fish was more than 10 times heavier than the ocean sunfish—the biggest bony fish alive today. Paleontologists have found only partial fossils of *Leedsichthys*, which makes it extremely difficult to calculate its precise size. Early research suggested that it may have rivaled the blue whale in length, but more recent findings have revealed that *Leedsichthys* was probably much smaller than the modern-day giant.

LARGEST
BONY FISH

AT A GLANCE

- **LENGTH** 36–54 ft (11–16.5 m)
- **DIET** Small marine animals
- **LIVED** 165–150 MYA
- **HABITAT** Oceans



STATS AND FACTS

45
YEARS
OLD
OLDEST KNOWN INDIVIDUAL

Fossils suggest that *Leedsichthys* probably grew at a slow rate over several years. Even so, by the age of 1, an individual would have reached a size of 5 ft (1.6 m). *Leedsichthys* was able to grow quickly in its first few years thanks to the rich food sources in Jurassic seas. Being so large from a young age would have kept it safe from predators.

WEIGHT



Scientists estimate that an adult *Leedsichthys* could have weighed up to 22 tons (20 tonnes), more than twice the weight of a T. rex.

GILL SIZE



One *Leedsichthys* fossil revealed gills over 3 ft (1 m) wide and 5 ft (1.5 m) long. Scientists think *Leedsichthys*'s large gills would have helped it take in enough oxygen for its large body.

Leedsichthys had a toothless mouth, similar to modern filter-feeding sharks and whales.